Bhava and Rasa in the Natya Shastra: An Aesthetic Framework of Indian Dramaturgy

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Abstract

The *Natya Shastra* of Bharata Muni remains one of the most influential treatises in world dramaturgy. It establishes a comprehensive aesthetic theory where emotion (*Bhava*) and its aesthetic relish (*Rasa*) constitute the essence of all performance arts. This paper explores the conceptual foundations of *Bhava* and *Rasa*, their classifications, psychological underpinnings, and the dynamic process through which aesthetic experience is evoked in the spectator.

1. Introduction: Natya Shastra as the Foundation of Indian Dramaturgy

The *Natya Shastra*, composed by Bharata Muni, is the foundational text of Indian performing arts. Often described as a codified compendium of theatrical regulations, it provides detailed prescriptions for dramaturgy, dance, music, and stagecraft. Beyond its structural and performative details, the treatise is remarkable for articulating an integrated theory of aesthetics — the doctrine of *Rasa*, or aesthetic relish.

Its contribution to world dramaturgy lies primarily in the introduction of this unique concept of *Rasa*, succinctly captured in Bharata's statement:

"Na hi rasād ṛte kaścid arthah pravartate" —
No meaningful idea is conveyed if *Rasa* is not evoked.

2. Understanding *Bhava*: The Seed of Emotional Experience

The term *Bhava* derives from the Sanskrit root *"bhū"* (to be), and can be interpreted as *"that which brings into being or awareness."* In the context of aesthetics, *Bhava* represents the psychological and emotional states that manifest within an individual — the raw experiential material which, through performance, culminates in *Rasa*.

"Bhāvayati iti bhāvaḥ" —
That which becomes or brings forth awareness.

Thus, *Bhava* can be understood as both an internal condition (*to be felt*) and a process of becoming (*to come into existence*).

3. Classification of *Bhava*

According to the *Natya Shastra*, *Bhava* is classified into three interrelated types, each contributing differently to the aesthetic process:

1. **Sthayi Bhava (Durable Emotional States)**
   These are the fundamental, enduring emotional dispositions inherent in human consciousness. They remain latent in the subconscious and can be awakened through appropriate stimuli(*Vibhava*). Each *Sthayi Bhava* corresponds to a primary *Rasa*.
   The eight *Sthayi Bhavas* are:
   - *Rati* (Love)
   - *Hasa* (Laughter/Amusement)
   - *Krodha* (Anger)
   - *Utsaha* (Energy or Heroism)
   - *Vismaya* (Wonder)
   - *Śoka* (Sorrow)
   - *Bhaya* (Fear)
   - *Jugupsa* (Disgust)
2. **Vyabhichari Bhava (Transitory Emotional States)**
   These are fleeting emotions that support and intensify the dominant *Sthayi Bhava*, aiding in its maturation into *Rasa*. Also called *Sanchari Bhavas*, they are 33 in number, encompassing a wide psychological spectrum — from *Nirveda* (weariness) and *Glāni* (fatigue) to *Harsa* (joy) and *Trāsa* (fright). While not all are experienced in a single performance, they collectively enrich emotional complexity.
3. **Sattvika Bhava (Involuntary Psychosomatic States)**
   These manifest as spontaneous physical expressions resulting from the unity of mind and body. Unlike deliberate gestures (*Anubhavas*), *Sattvika Bhavas* arise involuntarily and are born of *Sattva* — inner purity and emotional truth.
   The eight *Sattvika Bhavas* are:
   - *Stambha* (Paralysis)
   - *Sveda* (Perspiration)
   - *Romāñcha* (Goosebumps)
   - *Svarabhanga* (Faltering of Voice)
   - *Vepathu* (Trembling)
   - *Vaivarnya* (Change of Color)
   - *Aśru* (Tears)
   - *Pralaya* (Fainting)

4. From *Bhava* to *Rasa*: The Transformation

While *Bhava* denotes the emotional potential, *Rasa* signifies its aesthetic realization — the *relishing* or *enjoyment* of emotion in the consciousness of the sympathetic spectator (*Sahridaya*).
Bharata defines this transformation through the *Rasa Sutra*:

"Vibhāva-anubhāva-vyabhicāri-samyogād rasa-niṣpattiḥ"
Rasa arises from the harmonious combination of *Vibhava*, *Anubhava*, and *Vyabhichari Bhava*.

This process unfolds as follows:

- **Vibhava (Determinants):** The cause or stimulus that evokes emotion. It is of two types —
  - *Alambana Vibhava:* the central character or object.
  - *Uddipana Vibhava:* the surrounding environment or context that enhances emotional experience.
- **Anubhava (Consequent Expressions):** The visible manifestations of internal emotion through gestures, speech, or expressions.
- **Vyabhichari Bhava (Complementary Emotions):** The transient emotions that sustain and deepen the main sentiment.

Together, these elements culminate in *Rasa*, which the spectator experiences not as a personal emotion but as a universalized, aesthetic pleasure — much like tasting a flavor. The metaphor of taste aptly captures this: as we use the tongue to savor food, we use the heart to savor *Rasa*.

5. The Rasa Spectrum

Each *Sthayi Bhava* corresponds to a particular *Rasa* — forming the classical eightfold division (*Ashta Rasa*), with a ninth added later:

SthayiBhava	Rasa	Emotional Tone
Rati	Śṛṅgāra	Love / Erotic
Hasa	Hāsya	Comic / Joyful
Krodha	Raudra	Furious
Utsāha	Vīra	Heroic
Vismaya	Adbhuta	Marvelous
Śoka	Karuṇa	Pathetic / Compassionate
Bhaya	Bhayānaka	Terrifying
Jugupsa	Bībhatsa	Odious / Disgusting
Nirveda	Śānta	Peaceful (added later)

The inclusion of *Śānta Rasa*, associated with *Nirveda* (detachment), completes the emotional totality of human experience, extending the framework from aesthetic pleasure to spiritual realization.

6. The Relishing Process in Art Creation

In artistic performance, the *Rasa* is not a direct reflection of real emotion but its distilled, universalized essence. The performer acts as the medium, while the spectator experiences the emotional flavor purified of personal attachment.
The process may be represented as:

Stage	Element	Function
Cause	*Vibhava*	Stimulus triggering emotion
Expression	*Anubhava*	Performer's physical and verbal manifestation
Support	*Vyabhichari Bhava*	Transitory states enriching experience
Response	*Rasa*	Aesthetic relish within the spectator's heart

Thus, art becomes a transformative bridge between the personal and the universal, the emotional and the transcendental.

7. Conclusion

The *Bhava–Rasa* framework articulated by Bharata Muni continues to shape the theory and practice of Indian performing arts. It recognizes the interdependence of psychology, physiology, and aesthetics in evoking emotional experience. For performers, it serves as a guide to internalizing and transmitting emotion authentically; for audiences, it offers a pathway to spiritual empathy and catharsis.

Ultimately, as Bharata asserts, *Rasa* is the soul of performance — without it, no art can move, enlighten, or endure.

References

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